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8.1 Understanding the Master's Degree

Focus Questions:

- *What are the four types of master's degree?*
- *How long does it take to complete a master's degree?*

Master's students undertake the degree to achieve advanced knowledge of a specialized area of theory and practice (e.g., Master of Architecture). Upon graduation, they will possess skill in analysis and often practice, problem-solving, and independent work and thinking.

Master's programs can take as short a time as one year to complete and as long a time as six years, with two to three years being the average.

Some programs will require a thesis for graduation and others will not (the latter being more dependent on course work or practical work).

Most programs will require (1) a bachelor's degree for admission, (2) a minimum GPA score, and (3) minimum standardized test (e.g., GRE or GMAT) scores for admission. Some will also require work and/or research or publishing experience.

Some students will go on from master's degrees to doctoral degrees, while some will complete their school careers after the master's and use it to help them get the job they want in a certain field. Some doctoral degrees in the US require master's degrees as a prerequisite, while others require only a bachelor's degree.

These are some of the types of master's degrees available in the US:

- **Post-graduate master's degree:** This is designed for those who hold a bachelor's degree and who want to obtain a more advanced degree.

- **Post-graduate research master's degree:** This is designed for those who hold a bachelor's degree with a significant research component and/or have several publications. It is for those wishing to pursue higher research.
- **Executive master's degree:** This is a master's degree designed especially for executive professionals. Admission, graduation requirements, and structure of executive master's degrees differ from that of the regular full-time program.
- **Integrated master's degree:** This is an undergraduate degree combined with an extra master's year. The first 3 years of study are often the same as a bachelor's degree, followed by an additional year of study at a master's degree level. The degree is only conferred at the end of study as a full master's; an intermediate bachelor's degree is not awarded. Integrated master's are most common in scientific disciplines.

IMPORTANT: Not all master's degrees are designed for students who intend to go on to apply to a doctoral program. Those that do not are known as terminal master's programs. Most professional master's degrees are terminal in nature. Sometimes credits received in terminal master's programs may be transferable to a doctoral degree, but sometimes not. It is important that the student be aware of whether or not a master's program is terminal.

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